

CHAPTER 2: EAT BERRIES OR LEAVES. GET STRONGER.

As Catria stepped through the arch into the fae forest, she gasped in shock. Never had she seen anything like it. Sure, she'd been told what to expect, but seeing it was not at all what she expected. The land was beautiful in many ways. There were trees with sparkling leaves and brightly colored flowers gracing the landscape. Yet, there was also such a contrast with areas she could see that looked dark, somehow sad. The juxtaposition of the bright and dark was startling.

Catria looked around, feeling entirely unprepared despite all her preparation. Where was she going to go to look for the items she wanted. She fidgeted with the silver bracelet around her wrist. That was her metal. Hrod had told her there was a river good to find gems in north and east of the entrance, and that there were many trees all over. She was hoping to get some hair from a deer or a feather from a crane, as both represented healing. She definitely didn't want to kill an animal. Aschelleans often bragged about fighting bears, wolves, or other vicious

animals, but she didn't want to harm one.

She saw the group from Aschelle head east, so she decided to go northwest.

The woods were beautiful. She walked through admiring the different trees and flowers, forgetting her fear and almost forgetting to look for what she'd come to find.

There was a great variety of trees. She'd studied them to know what to try to find. Oak, Ash, and Hawthorn were considered the fairy trio, and very common choices for war mages. Oak represents strength, stability, and endurance, so many war mages wanted it. Ash represents protection, healing, and resilience, so it too was sought after. Catria had considered Ash for its healing, but it wasn't her first choice. Hawthorn represented protection, connection, and balance. Due to its thorny branches and serrated leaves, it often gave people vicious attacks. The small red berries did actually look tasty, much better than eating a leaf. Yet, she bypassed the normal trees.

She was walking through the trees, wondering if she should have gone northeast. After all, she'd been told there were several lakes that way, and Willow, the tree she was looking for, liked to grow near water. Yet, if what she's heard of Aschelle and Phyrn was true, they might try to sabotage her. And surely there would be rivers the direction she was headed.

She continued on. The beautiful landscape not changing, but something becoming eerie about it.

Someone, or something was watching her.

She looked around and called out, not very loudly, “Who’s there?”

No answer came, but a series of raspy, guttural coughs filled the air. Obviously, it was some sort of animal, but what type? Never has she heard such a sound.

She pulled her sword, prepared to fight, but her shaking hands made it hard to hold. She then ran for a tree. But what if the animal could climb a tree? She’d be better fighting it on the ground.

She gripped her sword tighter, trying to stabilize her hands. She’d fought wild animals before, but always with the help of the other war mages, and they were good.

A moment later, she found out what made the noise, as a leopard came bounding toward her. She froze in fear. How could she fight a leopard alone? They were incredibly fast runners, so she couldn’t run away, but they also had sharp teeth and claws, much deadlier than her sword. If only she’d found a willow tree and eaten her leaf already to get enhanced strength.

She struck at the leopard as it charged at her, but it slashed at her with its claws. She wore leather armor, so it didn’t cut deeply, but the claws stung.

She tried to focus to strike back, but suddenly, seemingly from no where, a whip came and struck the leopard. A deep, primal growl came from the wildcat and it turned and ran at a man standing not too far away.

Catria stared at the man, surprised she hadn't heard him come. Then again, she was distracted with the leopard.

The man seemed young, likely around her age, maybe a little older. He had dark hair, darker than hers, but very blue eyes. What captured her attention most was his clothes. He wore a cowboy hat, canvas pants, and a leather vest, not a jerkin or tunic style that so many men in Terrian wore. It was different. He was obviously from Cruia, the city farthest south of all seven of the cities.

Cruia didn't fight in the arena much. They never challenged, and for some reason, seldom were ever challenged, but when they did fight, they were good.

She knew little of the city, only that there were many farms and the war mages were all very tough.

She panicked as the leopard bounded toward the man. Should she try to run in and help, or would she only get in the way of his whip. The many seemed very proficient with it.

She didn't consciously make a decision, but stood, staring at the fight. The man was good and seemed to have no problem fighting the leopard. He stayed calm and kept the leopard back, striking with his whip.

When the leopard made it forward, the man pulled a long knife and struck at the leopard, cutting it across its front flank.

The leopard slashed with its claws as he did, and then it ran off into the woods.

“I guess it doesn’t want to play anymore,” the man stated as he walked over to Catria, his arm bleeding from the claws.

“Are you all right?” Catria asked. “Let me help you with those cuts.”

“They’re mere scratches,” the man responded. “I’m fine. I’ve had worse. In Cruia, we’re used to dealing with animals, both wild and domesticated. Can I help you? You’re bleeding.”

“It’s fine,” Catria assured him. “I’m not used to fighting wild animals, definitely not alone. I really appreciate your help. I can tell you are from Cruia. May I have your name?”

“Erik,” the man answered. “It’s good to meet you. You are?”

“Catria, from Terrian.”

“Terrian is obvious from your clothing,” Erik noted. “Plus, I’ve seen you around the Terrian team. Are you alone on this quest?”

Fear suddenly ran through Catria. What if he had some bad intention, and only saved her to sabotage her? Yet, she couldn’t bring herself to lie. “I am alone,” she admitted.

“Me too,” Erik noted. “Perhaps it’s best if we travel together. “What are you looking for?”

Should she tell him? Her team has warned her about trusting anyone, but obviously, she needed help, and he

seemed sincere. He had just saved her.

“Willow, clear quartz, and deer or crane,” she answered.

He chuckled. “You are better planned out than me. We aren’t big into planning what to get in Cruia. We just kind of pick up what feels right. Cruia isn’t as into lore as the other cities. We’re too busy breaking horses, tending to animals, and getting the work done. I’m a cattleman. I was told by a girl back home that I needed to get rowan. There aren’t many rowan trees in Cruia. I was shown one, so I hope I recognize it.”

“I can recognize rowan for you,” Catria assured him. A smile crossed her face. “Is the maiden who suggested it someone you court?”

“No,” he answered with a chuckle. “A friend of my sister, nice girl, but not my type. I’m more into the type of maiden who is feminine but not weak.” He held his hand out to her and suggested, “We should travel together. We’ll be safer that way, and it will be better company than being alone.”

She extended her hand. He took it and kissed it, then gave her a slight bow, and tipped his hat. “It’s nice to meet you Catria. Let’s get going.”

They walked through the woods. It didn’t take long before Catria pointed out a rowan tree. There were plenty.

“Rowan is supposed to ward off evil,” Catria explained as Erik picked several bright red berries.

“Are the berries poisonous?” he suddenly asked, as he stared at them in his hand.

“No,” Catria answered. “They can cause some stomach upset if you eat too many raw, but cooked they have no issues. You only need to eat one, so you will be fine.”

Erik sighed in relief then took a berries and stared at it before he popped it in his mouth. Eating a berry or leaf from a tree in the fae forest was a big deal. At the point someone ate their plant, he instantly would receive increased strength and there was no turning back from becoming a war mage.

Yet, Erik ate it. After he did, his eyes went wide and he stared at his hands, feeling the change that was taking place in his body. After a moment to process what had just happened, he exclaimed, “That was amazing.”

He then walked over to the tree to pick some leaves. He grabbed a branch, and accidentally broke it off. “I’ll have to be careful as I learn to adjust to my new strength,” he noted. He then carefully picked several leaves and a small twig and put them in a pouch on his belt. As soon as he did, he suggested, “Let’s go find your tree.”

They could hear the sound of running water in the distance, so they headed toward it, hoping to find willow near it.

They did come to the stream, and there were many trees. Several types of willow grew there.

Erik pointed at a weeping willow. “That’s willow, right?”

“Weeping willow,” Catria explained. “I’m looking for white willow.”

Erik cocked his head. “There are different types of willow? Willow isn’t just willow?”

Catria chuckled. “I assume you know cattle better than trees. If I said all cows are the same, you’d correct me.”

“Because they aren’t,” Erik defended.

“All willows aren’t either,” Catria explained.

She started looking around for a white willow. As she did, Erik went to the water, took his shirt off, and washed where he’d been clawed by the leopard.

Catria stopped and gawked at him shirtless. He was definitely muscular. Perhaps eating the rowan enhanced it. Either way, he was pleasing to the eye.

She shook her head to clear her thoughts of him and went back to looking for trees. It didn’t take too long to find a white willow. She stared at the tree, the moment of truth finally arriving. Once she ate a leaf, there was no turning back. She’d change. She’d get war mage strength and wasn’t supposed to leave the forest without an animal and stone. Those were easy to get, as anything could be picked up, but she wanted specific items.

She picked a leaf and brought it toward her mouth. Her hand stopped suddenly. Did she really want to do

this? What was eating a leaf going to taste like? Sure, she'd eaten many edible plants, but willow?

She took a deep breath and put the leaf in her mouth. The taste was odd, but she hardly noticed it. After all, she was changing. Her body felt different, definitely stronger.

After a moment, she took a leaf and bark from the tree, as the bark had the most healing properties. She put them in a pouch on her belt and headed toward Erik. He was putting his shirt back on.

Everything seemed to be going so smoothly until suddenly an arrow whizzed from the trees across the stream and hit her in the side.

She screamed as she felt the impact and heard her ribs crack. Pain as she'd never felt soared through her. Surely, she was going to die.

Her scream turned to silence, as her lungs gave out and she couldn't make a sound.

Through the pain, she could feel herself falling, but instead of landing on the ground or falling in the water, she felt herself fall into strong arms.

"I'm here," Erik assured her as he laid her gently on the ground and knelt beside her. "You're a war mage. You can heal from this. I'll keep you alive until you do."

His words were reassuring, but she could tell from his voice that he wasn't confident.

"Live," he pleaded. Yet, she closed her eyes, the world around her turning dark.

Erik wasn't sure what to do. He broke the arrow, pulled it out, and tried to stop the bleeding. Surely, there were plants in the fairy forest that could heal, but he knew nothing of them.

Her breathing became fainter, so he put his mouth to hers and breathed into it.

Then he listened to her heart. It was beating, but getting fainter. He couldn't let her die, but what could he do?

Everything felt so hopeless as he cried out, "Help! She must live!"